as there were no secured assets. The declared losses were Rs 37,385 up to 31 July 1907 and Rs 1,71,494 for the period between 1 August 1907 and 31 March 1908. Given that ‘preliminary expenses’ amounted to a total of Rs 60,000, of which Rs 20,000 were incurred after August 1907, the superintendent of police now turned an expert chartered accountant and argued that it could ‘hardly be called “preliminary”’. Next, donning the hat of a ship surveyor, he contested the book value of the two steamers. The increase in the value of the steamers, by Rs 57,000 between August 1907 and March 1908, was also disputed. ‘There has undoubtedly been swindling and mismanagement,’ he concluded with certitude. Indulging in wishful thinking, he hoped that ‘if some shareholder or shareholders made a public fuss about the accounts’ a public inquiry could be conducted. If no one raised the issue, it was not for want of trying—his attempt to incite some shareholders had failed.[30]

Further analysis of SSNCo’s finances turned up more than six months later. In early February 1909, the collector of Madurai, H.F.W. Gillman revisited these accounts. On a private visit to Colombo, Gillman went out of his way to collect information on the SSNCo and filed a long report even though Tirunelveli district was not in his charge. Such, it would seem, was the call of imperial duty. Not only did he ‘take the opportunity of making enquiries about the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company’, he also followed them up on his return to office. Patting his own back, he remarked, ‘Much of what I have been told does not appear to have reached the CID and seems worthy of record.’[31]

Firstly, Gillman questioned the figures provided in the company’s balance sheet. Claiming to be ‘credibly informed’ on this score, he gave alternate figures.